

The dangers of aviation

The aerobatic American pilot Lincoln Beachey always flew in a business suit, to emphasize what an easy, everyday matter flying was, but for most people, the drama and thrills of races, stunts, and shows only underlined the dangers of aviation.

The rising death toll among aviators was something that eventually neither governments nor the fledgling aviation industry could ignore. A total of 32 pilots were killed in 1910, and another 30 died in the first six months of the following year – at a time when there were probably fewer than 600 fliers worldwide. In 1911 the French government set up a commission to inquire into measures for protecting aviators, resulting in the first flight regulations, including a ban on flying over towns and crowds.

Level-headed citizens were inclined to dismiss pilots as “flying fools” addicted to a dangerous sport. When Winston Churchill, then Britain’s First Lord of the Admiralty, took up flying just before World War I, his wife and friends begged him to refrain from what they regarded as a suicidal obsession. Churchill eventually gave in after his wife told him: “Every time I see a telegram now I think it is to announce that you have been killed flying.” Private fliers fell broadly into two categories: wealthy individuals who saw in flying a thrill or a challenge; and mechanically



THE FIRST PARACHUTE JUMP

IN 1912, HEAVIER-THAN-AIR AVIATORS began to experiment with parachutes, which were already in widespread use by balloonists. The first parachute jump from a powered airplane was made by an American, Captain Albert Berry, over Jefferson Barracks, Missouri. He was testing a “parachute carrying and dispensing means carried by an airplane,” which later received a US patent for its inventors, Tom Benoist and Tony Jannus, the pilot. Asked if he would repeat

the performance, Berry replied: “Never again! I believe I turned five somersaults on my way down... My course downward... was like a crazy arrow. I was not prepared for the violent sensation that I felt when I broke away from the airplane.”

Parachuting was taken up by the French acrobatic pilot, Adolphe Pégoud, who made it a part of his aerial displays. Parachutes did not, however, become a standard item of a pilot’s kit. Fliers regarded them as impossibly bulky and, in any case, of little use in most of the types of accident to which they were prone.

Parachute pulled from conical container attached to landing skid



DOWN TO EARTH

Captain Albert Berry (wearing a cap) made the first parachute jump from a powered airplane on March 1, 1912. Berry jumped from a height of 1,500ft (460m) over Jefferson Barracks, St. Louis, Missouri, from a Benoist biplane (above).



A VIOLENT END

Human error was a major cause of crashes. In the early days, pilots had only a sketchy idea of the hazards involved. They often flew too low over the ground, creating the risk of hitting obstacles and giving no time for recovery if something went wrong.

gifted working men, who dreamed of making their fortune out of prize money or exhibitions. Pilots also included a few women, ready to brave not only the physical risks of flying but also the prejudices of their male-dominated society. Hélène Dutrieu, a Belgian aviatrix, and Harriet Quimby, the first American woman to gain a pilot’s license, won suitable renown for their aviation exploits, but interest in them often focused more on the elegance of their flying outfits than their evident skill and bravery.

Learning to fly

Flying schools proliferated, especially in France, as increasing numbers of people came forward to